Reptile glossary

Arboreal creatures that live in trees or spend a lot of time there.

Backbone (spine) a flexible chain of bones running down an animal's back. Animals with a backbone, such as reptiles, are called vertebrates.

Camouflage the way animals hide by blending in with their natural surroundings.

Clutch a number of eggs all laid at the same time.

Cold-blooded an animal that uses its natural surroundings to warm up or cool down.

Dinosaurs prehistoric reptiles that once ruled the world, but died out 65 million years ago.

Display showing off parts of the body to attract a mate or defend a territory.

Evolution over very long periods of time, all creatures develop (evolve) different skills and features that help them to cope with, or adapt to, their habitat. This is known as evolution.

Freshwater freshwater habitats are watery homes that are not salty, such as ponds and rivers.

Glands parts of an animal's body that can squeeze out substances such as venom, sweat, stinky musk, and salt.



Python skeleton

Habitat the natural home and surroundings of a living creature.

Hatchlings the name for baby animals that emerge from eggs.

Jacobson's organ a sense organ in the mouth of snakes and lizards, which allows them to "smell" and "taste" their surroundings using their tongues.

Keratin a horny substance that forms strong, flexible fibers and makes up part of a reptile's scales.

Mating season a period when male and female animals mate to produce new offspring (young).

Molting or sloughing getting rid of (shedding) old skin and scales.

Order a grouping of related animal types (species).

Pigment a substance inside body cells, such as skin cells, that produces color.

Pineal eye the name for the small, "third eye" that many lizards have.

Predator an animal that hunts and eats other animals.

Prehensile body parts, such as a coiled tail, that are good at gripping on to things.

Prey an animal that is hunted and eaten by other animals (predators).

Saltwater saltwater habitats are places such as seas, oceans, and river estuaries.

Scales the thin, overlapping, waterproof plates that cover a reptile's skin.

Scutes the large, tough, horny scales – such as those on tortoise and turtle shells, snakes' bellies, and the armored skin of *Crocodilians*.

Senses the five main senses are eyesight, hearing, smell, touch, and taste – but some snakes can also sense heat.

Skeleton the bony framework that supports and protects an animal's body.

Species a group of animals that share similar characteristics (features) and breed together to produce fertile young.

Venom a poisonous liquid that some reptiles (mainly snakes) use for hunting or self-defense.

